

Va. voters clear way to redraw districts

Democrats stand to gain as many as four seats in U.S. redistricting war

BY GREGORY S. SCHNEIDER AND PRAVEENA SOMASUNDARAM

RICHMOND — Virginia voters approved a referendum to draw new congressional districts that could add as many as four Democratic seats to the House of Representatives, the Associated Press projects, awarding Democrats an advantage in the national redistricting war begun by Republicans.

Democrats and their allies poured at least \$64 million into the Virginia campaign in a high-stakes bid to counter President Donald Trump's push to add Republican seats in other states. Voters rewarded the effort, continuing momentum Democrats built with big wins in Virginia's statewide elections last fall.

Though voters had said in polls that they generally opposed partisan gerrymandering, many said they were willing to approve it for a limited time to send an extraordinary message to the White House.

The Associated Press estimates that 3 million Virginians cast ballots, or 48 percent of registered voters, compared with 55 percent of voters in last year's gubernatorial election.

Early voting began March 6 and nearly 1.37 million early ballots had been cast as of Saturday, according to state figures, compared with about 1.5 million early votes in the 2025 election.

At least \$93 million — most of it in untraceable "dark money" — financed the contest, with supporters of the measure outspending opponents. National Democrats view the state as the biggest prize still available in the national redistricting arms race ahead of this fall's midterm congressional elections.

Trump sparked the costly effort last year by pushing Republican-led states to create more GOP-SEE VIRGINIA ON A5



MARKO DJURICA/REUTERS

Mourners in Kfar Sir, Lebanon, attend a Friday funeral for people, including Hezbollah members, who were killed during the conflict with Israel before a 10-day ceasefire went into effect.

Vast conspiracy probe of Trump foes gains steam

Clapper, Brennan among the Obama-era officials called in by Justice Dept.

BY PERRY STEIN

The Justice Department is barreling ahead with its broad conspiracy investigation into Democratic administration officials, summoning former intelligence officials for interviews and making major shake-ups in the Florida-based prosecutorial team.

The wide-ranging investigation is based on an unusual and untested legal theory: that previous administrations conspired for years to violate President Donald Trump's rights through a series of investigations, beginning with the Obama administration's examination of ties between Russia and

Trump's 2016 presidential campaign.

The conspiracy investigation, among the biggest and most legally complicated that the Justice Department is pursuing as part of Trump's vow to prosecute his political enemies, appears to be gaining momentum. The probe in part is looking at the decade-old actions of former officials in President Barack Obama's administration, including former director of national intelligence James R. Clapper Jr. and former CIA director John Brennan, who played significant roles in investigating the Russia ties.

The Justice Department in recent days tapped Joseph diGenova, a Trump loyalist, to lead the investigation, which is largely based out of Florida but also has a presence in D.C. DiGenova was an attorney on the president's campaign and has bolstered the baseless theory SEE FLORIDA ON A8

Two CIA drug officers in Mexico die in car wreck

The crash also took the lives of two Mexican officials

BY WARREN P. STROBEL AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

Two U.S. Embassy officials who died in an automobile accident in northern Mexico as they returned from the scene of a counternarcotic operation worked for the Central Intelligence Agency as part of a significantly expanded role in battling narcotics trafficking in the Western Hemisphere, according to two people familiar with the matter.

The deadly car crash Sunday in the state of Chihuahua also took the lives of two Mexican officials and prompted Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum to say she

would investigate whether the operation ran afoul of the country's national security laws.

The CIA declined to comment.

The four died as they were returning from meeting with Mexican officials in the aftermath of the operation to dismantle a clandestine drug lab in a remote area. Chihuahua's attorney general, César Jáuregui Moreno, told Mexico's El Universal newspaper that the Americans did not directly participate in the Mexican raid on the lab, which he called "perhaps one of the largest ever located."

Mexican officials said the car skidded off the road, fell down a ravine and exploded.

The accident comes amid increasing pressure from President Donald Trump on Mexico to take more action against the cartels, and as the CIA has broadened its counternarcotics operations in the country and elsewhere in Latin SEE MEXICO ON A13

Trump extends truce in Iran

SCHEDULED TALKS CALLED OFF FOR NOW

Tehran says blockade is a violation of ceasefire

BY SAMMY WESTFALL, VICTORIA CRAW, NATALIE ALLISON AND MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

President Donald Trump announced Tuesday that he would extend a ceasefire with Iran hours before it was due to expire, pledging to refrain from attacks until discussions with Tehran "are concluded, one way or the other."

Trump said Iran's leadership was "seriously fractured" and needed to "come up with a unified proposal."

Trump made the announcement of an indefinite ceasefire as talks scheduled to take place between U.S. and Iranian delegations in the Pakistani capital were postponed amid uncertainty about the broad strokes of a deal. Vice President JD Vance and other U.S. negotiators remained in Washington instead of leaving for Islamabad as originally planned.

The decision to extend the ceasefire marked a significant shift for Trump, who earlier in the day had said that if a deal was not reached by Wednesday, he expected to "be bombing, because that is a better attitude to go in with." He added that the military was "raring to go."

His reversal had the effect of handing the initiative to Tehran, which has reveled in its ability to dial up pressure on global energy markets through its stranglehold over the Strait of Hormuz. And it was the latest measure of Trump's appetite for renewed conflict, which for now appears low.

In his announcement about the extension, Trump said he had SEE IRAN ON A12

Blockade: Operations expand to Indian Ocean in tanker capture. A12

Teaching model pushed by right strikes a chord

Classical schools focusing on U.S. ideals, Western content gain in popularity

BY LAUREN LUMPKIN

PALM BAY, FLA. — Seniors at Pineapple Cove Classical Academy draw upon the Bible and books from the Western canon to answer a quintessential question in their capstone project: What is the good life?

Children at the K-12 school learn Latin, engage in the Socratic method and write in cursive. The use of technology is rare. Students walk past paintings of historical scenes that include Betsy Ross sewing an American flag and down hallways lined with portraits of the Founding Fathers.

"We are going to honor the creation of our flag. We are going to honor George Washington," Lisa Wheeler, principal of the Palm Bay campus, said of the school. She wants students to graduate with an "understanding

of the Western civilization" and an appreciation for "the great people who founded our country."

The model at the Florida school, known as classical education, emphasizes Western history and literature, and draws on teaching methods from ancient Greece and Rome. The approach has found new popularity among families who say the methods offer more rigor than schools that have relaxed their grading policies or use screens for much of their teaching. And, supporters argue, the Eurocentric content is more proven than evolving modern teachings.

While the model is apolitical, it is also being pushed by conservatives, who say it celebrates American ideals and Western thought. Classical education's newfound popularity comes as the Trump administration seeks to promote patriotism and frames criticism of the darker chapters of U.S. history as un-American. The president is also attempting to eliminate diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives from schools, governments and workplaces.

SEE EDUCATION ON A6

Building bridges while breaking bread

Black and Jewish college students seek common ground amid divisions over Gaza war

BY SUSAN SVRLUGA



MAXINE WALLACE/THE WASHINGTON POST

For Christy Hill, a junior at the University of the District of Columbia, a Unity Dinner at George Washington University in November "was my first time interacting with Jews."

The Unity Dinner began awkwardly, with scores of strangers picking at plates of salmon in a campus ballroom. College students read icebreaker questions and fumbled through answers.

When a George Washington University freshman picked up a mic to answer whether a hot dog is a sandwich and jokingly cited the teachings of the Talmud, half the room laughed out loud. But the other half looked blank.

And when someone called out, "H.U.!" many people smiled and yelled the expected response from Howard University students: "YOU know!"

The rest looked surprised. They had no idea.

The guests, about half Black and half Jewish, were invited to the dinner at GWU late last year as part of a national effort to combat racism, antisemitism and other forms of bigotry. The initiative was launched by three philanthropic heavy hitters: the UNCF, Hillel International and the Blue Square Alliance Against SEE UNITY ON A2

IN THE NEWS

House Democrat steps down Rep. Sheila Cherfilus-McCormick (Florida) was indicted last year on charges that she stole and laundered federal disaster money. A8

Shots optional The military will no longer require troops to get the annual flu vaccine, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said. A9

THE NATION Democrats are aiming for midterm upsets in districts that Trump safely won in 2024. A4 Fed chair nominee Kevin Warsh fielded questions, but his confirmation is in limbo. A7

THE WORLD A trial began for a man accused of assisting the Kabul airport attack that killed 13 U.S. troops. A12 Japan will begin selling lethal weapons abroad, a major shift from its post-WWII pacifism. A13

THE ECONOMY Keeping money in separate accounts can build a wall between you and your spouse, Michelle Singletary writes. A14

STYLE An animated spin-off to the wildly popular "Stranger Things" turns the sci-fi saga's aesthetic upside down. B1

SPORTS After leading UCLA to a title, Lauren Betts now looks to anchor a young Mystics squad. B7

THE REGION D.C. legislators approved a permanent youth curfew to respond to mass gatherings of young people in buzzy corridors. B13

D.C. Water is facing two lawsuits over the January leak of untreated wastewater into the Potomac River. B13

FOOD Green vegetables such as asparagus, peas and herbs can enliven any dish, no matter what you're in the mood for.

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